一枚邮票改变通信

The Stamp That Changed the Post



一枚邮票怎样简化寄信，又怎样防止重复使用?

英文原文

Before 1840, British **postage** was **levied** according to the number of **sheets** in a letter and the **mileage** of its **carriage**. The sum was usually **payable** on **delivery**, so the person receiving the **correspondence**, not the **sender**, settled it. Prices thus **fluctuated** from one **postal item** to the next.

In 1837 Rowland Hill published a **booklet** urging reform. Parliament **enacted** the **campaigner**'s **proposal** in 1839, and on 10 January 1840 the Uniform Penny Post began. A letter of up to half an **ounce** now cost one **penny** to any **destination** in Britain, and the fee was **prepaid** by whoever sent it. One **flat-rate charge** replaced **variation** with **simplicity**.

The Penny Black, a one-penny **denomination**, was released on 1 May 1840, its **validity** starting on 6 May. **Engraved** on it was a **youthful likeness** of Queen Victoria, the **reigning monarch**. An **aggregate** of 68,808,000 were printed. The sheets had no holes for **separation**, so each stamp was cut out **individually** with **scissors**.

Mailings doubled, from about 80 million **items** in 1839 to over 169 million in 1840. The design had a **drawback**. Against black, the red **cancelling mark** was barely **noticeable**, lacking **contrast**, and the ink could be **erased**, leaving stamps **vulnerable to reuse**. In February 1841 the Penny Red, cancelled in black ink, arrived to **deter tampering** and **fraud**.

As the **initiator** of postage stamps, Britain set a **precedent** and earned an **exemption**. Its stamps are **nameless**, with no country **inscribed** on them. By international agreement, the **sovereign**'s head **suffices for identification**, an **implicit designation** that other countries spell out in print.

中文译文

1840年以前，英国的邮费是根据一封信件中的纸张数量及其运输的里程来征收的。这笔钱通常是在投递时应支付的，所以，收到信件的人，而非寄信人，结清邮费。价格此种方式波动，从一件邮政物品到下一件。

1837年，罗兰·希尔出版了一本小册子，呼吁改革。议会于1839年立法通过了这位改革倡导者的提议，并且在1840年1月10日，“统一便士邮资”开始实行。一封重量不超过半盎司的信，现在寄往英国境内任何目的地都只花费一便士，并且费用由寄信的人预付。一种统一收费以简便取代了差异。

黑便士，一枚面值一便士的邮票，发行于1840年5月1日，它的有效性从5月6日开始。它的上面雕刻着维多利亚女王年轻的肖像，即这位在位的君主。总计有68,808,000枚被印制。这些整版邮票没有用于分离的孔，所以每枚邮票都被单独地用剪刀剪下。

邮寄量翻了一番，从1839年的约8000万件邮寄物品增至1840年的超过1.69亿件。这一设计有个缺点。在黑色底色上，红色注销印记几乎不显眼，由于缺乏反差，且墨水能被擦除，导致邮票容易被重复使用。1841年2月，用黑色墨水盖销的“红便士”问世，旨在防止篡改与欺诈。

作为邮票的首创者，英国开创了先例，并赢得一项豁免。英国邮票是无名的，上面没有刻印国名。根据国际协议，（英国的）君主头像足以用于进行识别，这是一种隐含的标识，然而其他国家则需要把国名印在邮票上。

词汇与表达

postage n.
邮费
British postage was levied

levied v.
征收
levied according to the number

sheets n.
纸张

mileage n.
里程
the mileage of its carriage

carriage n.
运输

payable adj.
应支付的
usually payable on delivery

delivery n.
投递

correspondence n.
信件
receiving the correspondence

sender n.
寄信人

fluctuated v.
波动
Prices thus fluctuated

postal adj.
邮政

item n.
物品

booklet n.
小册子

enacted v.
立法通过了
Parliament enacted

campaigner n.
改革倡导者

proposal n.
提议
the campaigner's proposal

ounce n.
盎司

penny n.
便士

destination n.
目的地

prepaid adj.
预付
the fee was prepaid

flat-rate charge adj.
统一收费
One flat-rate charge

variation n.
差异

simplicity n.
简便

denomination n.
面值
a one-penny denomination

validity n.
有效性
its validity starting on 6 May

Engraved v.
雕刻

youthful adj.
年轻的

likeness n.
肖像

词汇与表达（续）

reigning adj.
在位的

monarch n.
君主

aggregate n.
总计
aggregate of 68,808,000

separation n.
分离

individually adv.
单独地

scissors n.
剪刀

Mailings n.
邮寄量
Mailings doubled

items n.
物品

drawback n.
缺点
The design had a drawback

cancelling mark n.
注销印记
the red cancelling mark

noticeable adj.
显眼

contrast n.
反差
lacking contrast

erased v.
擦除

vulnerable to adj.
容易被
vulnerable to reuse

reuse n.
重复使用

deter v.
防止
to deter tampering and fraud

tampering n.
篡改

fraud n.
欺诈
to deter tampering and fraud

initiator n.
首创者

precedent n.
先例
Britain set a precedent

exemption n.
豁免
earned an exemption

nameless adj.
无名的

inscribed v.
刻印

sovereign n.
君主

suffices for v.
足以用于

identification n.
识别

implicit adj.
隐含的

designation n.
标识

文章简述

- 旧制：英国邮费原按信纸数量和运输距离计算，通常由收信人付款，每封信的价格不一。
- 改革：1840年1月起，希尔推动的改革让半盎司（约14克）以内的信在英国境内统一收一便士，由寄件人预付。
- 邮票：同年5月，印有维多利亚女王头像、面值一便士的黑色邮票发行，称为“黑便士”；当年邮寄量由上年约8000万件增至1.69亿多件。
- 改进：黑票上的红色邮戳不显眼，红墨又容易被洗掉，邮票可能被重复使用；1841年改发红便士并盖黑戳。
- 特例：英国因首创邮票获国际特例，不必印国名，用君主头像就能识别国家；其他国家则要把国名印出。